Wearing the Imagined Community: Hanfu, Social Media, and the Embodied Nation in Contemporary China

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1. Introduction

In July 2022, French luxury brand Christian Dior released a midi skirt priced at 29,000 RMB. The garment quickly ignited public outrage across Chinese social media, as thousands of users accused Dior of copying the mǎmiànqún (马面裙, horse-face skirt), a traditional Han Chinese garment, while describing it on its website as an "iconic Dior silhouette" without acknowledging its cultural origins. On the Chinese version of its website, Dior chose silence. People discovered that the product was quietly removed, and no official apology was issued. Yet on the social media platform Xiaohongshu (RedNote), the controversy evolved into a wide-ranging public discussion about national identity, cultural respect, and Chinese nationalism. The Dior controversy was not an isolated incident but a crystallisation of an affective nationalism that had long been developing within the Hanfu movement, defining as a grassroots cultural revival centred on wearing traditional Han Chinese clothing, which emerged from internet subcultures in the early 2000s and has since grown into a mass youth phenomenon closely intertwined with broader subcultural currents alongside Lolita fashion and cosplay.

2. Problématique

This episode appears, on its surface, to be a brand crisis. But it reflects a deeper academic question: how do ordinary internet users participate in the construction of the national imagined community through social media in the digital age? In particular, when a specific material object, in this case is the mǎmiànqún becomes the focal point, how does online discourse translate into collective identity formation?

Benedict Anderson (1983) argued that nations are imagined communities brought into being through print capitalism, by the shared, simultaneous reading of newspapers and novels producing a sense of horizontal solidarity among strangers. This paper argues that digital Hanfu communities reveal the limits of this framework. In the twenty-first century, national imaginaries are increasingly produced not through reading but through embodied, visual, and performative practices, such as wearing, photographing, posting, and commenting; circulated across social media platforms. The medium has changed, and with it the logic of communal imagination: the body itself becomes the site through which the nation is collectively produced and affirmed. Michael Billig's (1995) concept of banal nationalism provides a complementary lens, referring to the everyday, unremarkable flagging of national identity through mundane cultural practices that is periodically intensified into explicit nationalist mobilisation by external provocations such as perceived Western cultural appropriation.

Drawing on these two frameworks, this study systematically analyses 196 relevant

posts on Xiaohongshu. The central hypothesis is that discourse surrounding the Dior controversy constitutes a highly decentralised, polyphonic process of national imagination, in which ordinary users participate in and reinforce communal consciousness through discussion of traditional clothing culture.

3. Literature Review

2.1 The Internet and National Sentiment

In contemporary China, the relationship between online discourse and nationalism has become a significant scholarly focus. Zhang et al. (2018) analysed over 6,000 Weibo posts and found that online political expression is not dominated by nationalism alone; anti-regime sentiment was more prevalent, and nationalist viewpoints exhibited significant internal differentiation. This suggests that online national sentiment is more complex and heterogeneous than surface-level observation might indicate. Schneider (2018) further argues that digital nationalism in China should be understood through a media-technological lens, as platform architectures actively shape how national sentiment is expressed and circulated. Liu (2024) demonstrates that Han-centric nationalist discourse on Weibo operates through specific rhetorical strategies that construct boundaries of cultural belonging, a dynamic directly relevant to the Hanfu movement's assertions of cultural ownership.

Recent studies of Xiaohongshu users show that national identity, geopolitical views, and cultural distance jointly shape emotional patterns and interaction modes on the platform (Guarnieri, 2025). As a lifestyle-oriented platform centred on "notes" and product recommendations, Xiaohongshu has a distinct user base and discussion style compared to Weibo, warranting dedicated investigation.

Alexander's (2003) theory of social performance provides a second theoretical lens. Hanfu wearers and digital protesters during the Dior controversy are not merely expressing pre-existing nationalist sentiment, but actively performing national identity for a digital audience. The staging of authenticity, collective commitment, and cultural legitimacy mirrors the performative logic Alexander identifies in social movements and political action. Hebdige's (1979) concept of subcultural recuperation offers another angle that the Hanfu movement's strong nationalist charge complicates the standard recuperation narrative, since commercial incorporation does not necessarily neutralise a practice whose resistant potential is tied to national rather than class identity.

2.2 Methodological Paradigms

Keyword and hashtag analysis has become a standard method in social media discourse research. Song et al. (2025) demonstrate the power of temporal pattern mining and hashtag-based storyline construction for tracking how events evolve on social media, providing a methodological foundation for the temporal analysis

employed in this study. Zhao et al. (2025) employed a netnographic approach to analyse algorithmic resistance across Douyin, Xiaohongshu, and Weibo, demonstrating that thematic analysis can handle large-scale data while preserving qualitative detail. During the COVID-19 pandemic, researchers analysed 50,249 Weibo comments using SnowNLP for sentiment recognition, LDA for topic extraction, and sample coding for qualitative depth (Luo et al., 2021), establishing a mixed-methods paradigm for contemporary discourse analysis. Chen et al. (2023) further note the practical challenges of social media data collection, including platform access restrictions, data quality control, and ethical considerations around user privacy, all of which inform the methodological choices made in this study.

4. Methodology

4.1 Data Collection

Data were collected from Xiaohongshu using the xiaohongshu-cli tool, an open-source command-line interface for extracting publicly available post data from the platform. Three parallel keyword searches were employed:

1) "迪奥 马面裙": Dior horse-face skirt, the core event keyword
2) "文化挪用": Cultural appropriation, a theoretical framework term
3) "#迪奥马面裙": A hashtag for precise search, combining 2 words in (1).

Each search returned approximately 80–150 results, yielding 206 posts in total. For

each post, the following metadata were recorded: post ID, author, author ID, date, likes, comments, collections, shares, title, content, note type, and search keyword. This multi-keyword strategy was designed to capture both the event-specific discourse and the broader theoretical framing through which users interpreted the controversy.

4.2 Data Screening

A binary relevance coding scheme was applied. In the collected dataset, posts directly related to the Dior controversy, mǎmiànqún discussion, or cultural identity were coded as "relevant". Of the 206 posts, 196 (95.1%) were deemed relevant and included in the analysis.

4.3 Thematic and Sentiment Coding

Posts were classified into five thematic categories using keyword matching. Plagiarism Accusation captured posts containing terms such as "plagiarism", "copy", or "theft". Cultural Appropriation identified discussions featuring "cultural appropriation" or related terminology. National Pride encompassed posts emphasising "national confidence", guofeng (national style), or "cultural heritage". Commercial Critique covered posts focused on pricing, false advertising, or other commercial concerns. The residual category, Other, captured the substantial volume of posts engaging multiple frames simultaneously or addressing the controversy from angles, such as historical analysis, design comparison, or personal reflection, not reducible to the four primary categories.

Sentiment was classified into four categories:

- Critical: signalled by terms such as "anger", "shameless", "outrageous";
- Supportive: signalled by "support", "pride", "beautiful";
- Neutral: informational or analytical tone without clear evaluative direction;
- Confused: expressing uncertainty or ambivalence.

4.4 Temporal Scope

The data spans July 2022 to October 2025, covering the controversy's full lifecycle. The individual post served as the unit of analysis, with opinion leaders (authors appearing ≥2 times) tracked separately.

5. Findings

5.1 Thematic Distribution

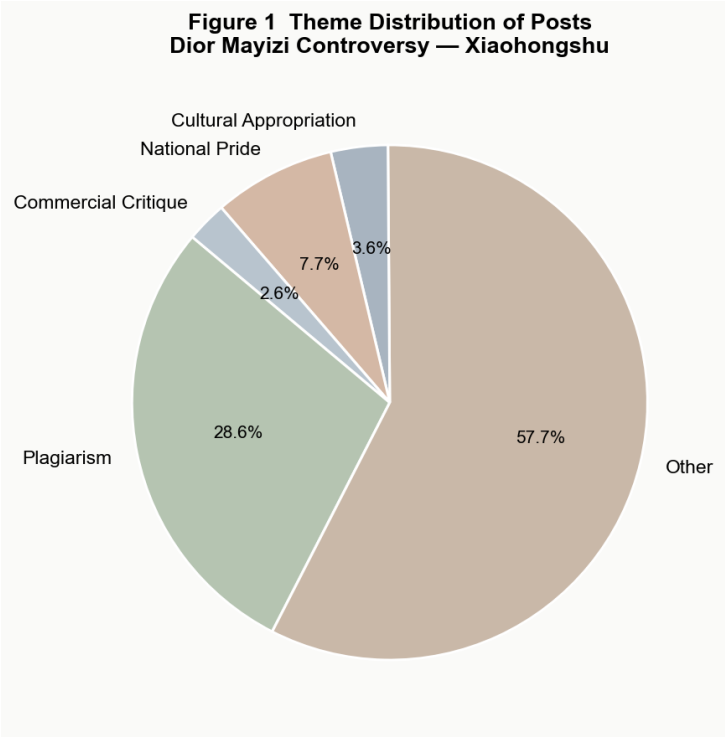
Among the 196 relevant posts, the "Other" category encompassing diverse discussions not reducible to a single frame accounted for the largest share at

57.7% (n=113). Plagiarism Accusation constituted 28.6% (n=56), followed by National Pride at 7.7% (n=15), Cultural Appropriation at 3.6% (n=7), and Commercial Critique at 2.6% (n=5).

The dominance of "Other" indicates that discourse was not structured by a binary opposition of "plagiarism or not". Users engaged with multiple analytical

frameworks including legal argumentation, cultural reflection, and commercial analysis.

This pluralism is precisely the hallmark of what Anderson terms the imagined community. It is not a unified opinion, but a convergence of many individual acts of imagination. The sheer diversity of the "Other" category, which included historical comparisons between Chinese and European textile traditions, technical analyses of garment construction, personal narratives of wearing Hanfu, and broader reflections on East-West cultural relations, suggests that the controversy functioned as a catalyst for wide-ranging cultural self-examination rather than a simple binary of "for or against Dior".



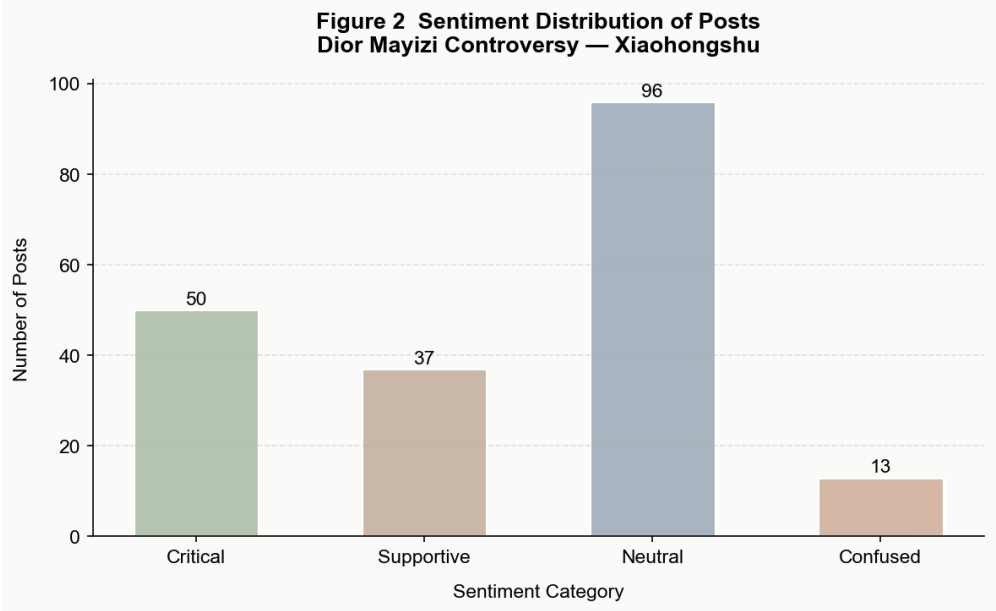
Data Source: Manually collected from Xiaohongshu

Figure 1

4.2 Sentiment Distribution

Neutral posts constituted the largest category at 49.0% (n=96), followed by Critical at 25.5% (n=50), Supportive at 18.9% (n=37), and Confused at 6.6% (n=13).

The prevalence of neutral discussion almost 50% challenges the stereotype of "angry online mobs". Users were engaged in rational, multidimensional deliberation: analysing legal questions, debating design ethics, and reflecting on the contemporary value of traditional culture. This is not indifference but what might be termed a rational imagination process. From Billig's (1995) perspective, the maintenance of national consciousness does not depend on peaks of collective passion, but on everyday, rational cultural discussions.



Data Source: Manually collected from Xiaohongshu

Figure 2

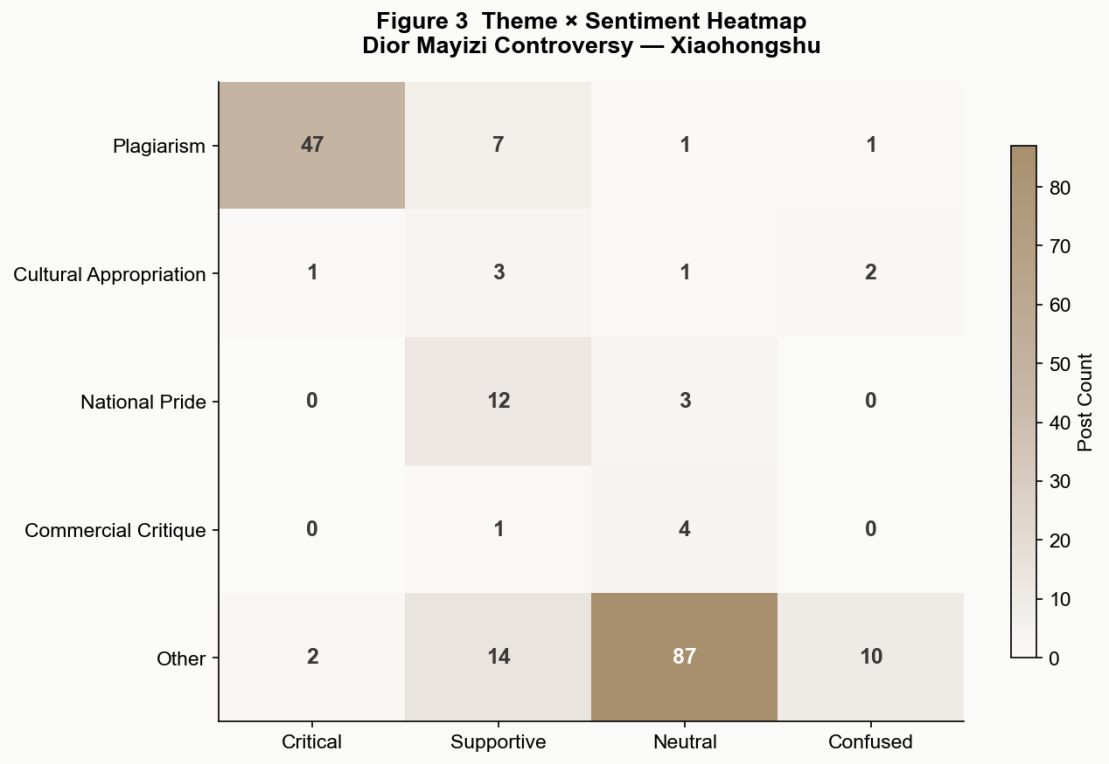
Our data supports this: nearly half of participants adopted an analytical rather than condemnatory stance. The balance between Critical (25.5%) and Supportive (18.9%) further indicates that the discourse was not a one-sided denunciation but a genuine deliberative space where multiple evaluative positions coexisted. The relatively small proportion of Confused posts (6.6%) suggests that most users arrived at the discussion with pre-formed frameworks for interpretation, even if those frameworks did not lead to uniform conclusions.

4.3 Theme–Sentiment Cross-Analysis

Different thematic frames elicited markedly different emotional responses. Among Plagiarism Accusation posts, 83.9% (47 of 56) expressed Critical sentiment, while only 1.8% were Neutral, indicating that the plagiarism frame was overwhelmingly evaluative and morally charged. Users who adopted this frame typically advanced three types of arguments: that traditional culture lacks intellectual property protection mechanisms, that design similarity does not necessarily constitute legal infringement, and that moral responsibility should be distinguished from legal liability.

In the National Pride category, 80.0% (12 of 15) were Supportive with 0% Critical, demonstrating high consensus when discussion shifted toward cultural confidence. Posts in this frame tended to emphasise the aesthetic value, historical depth, and contemporary revival of Hanfu, constructing a positive national imagination.

The "Other" category exhibited a strikingly different profile. 77.0% Neutral (87 of 113), reflecting analytically detached discussions that transcended any single frame. This pattern suggests that the majority of participants were not emotionally invested partisans but reflective observers engaging the controversy as an occasion for cultural learning.



Data source: Manually collected from Xiaohongshu

Figure 3

4.4 Engagement and Decentralisation

Likes followed a long-tail distribution: mean 1,194, median 112, with 66.8% of posts receiving fewer than 500 likes. This disparity indicates that a small number

of viral posts coexisted alongside a large volume of modest-engagement content, consistent with the algorithmic amplification patterns characteristic of platform-mediated discourse. The comment-to-like ratio stood at 4.5%, below the conventional threshold for "high engagement" (10%). However, this does not indicate shallow discussion; rather, Xiaohongshu users' engagement pattern favours reading and liking over commenting. The platform's "note" format encourages long-form, knowledge-rich content creation, and the most-liked posts frequently contained substantive historical analysis, legal discussion, or design critique, suggesting meaningful learning and deliberation.

The Decentralisation Index was 98.0%: only four authors appeared two or more times (@小红薯 68CE673A, @Fashion Area, @咩咕拉斯, and @Ran.), each contributing exactly two posts. This contrasts sharply with Weibo's "Big V" ecosystem where a handful of influencers routinely dominate trending topics. Ordinary users were the primary drivers of the topic, consistent with Anderson's model, as stated before, national imagination is constructed not by elites but by ordinary individuals participating in a shared discursive space.

4.5 Word Frequency Analysis

High-frequency term analysis revealed that terms of cultural affirmation ("culture" (文化), "tradition" (传统), "Hanfu" (汉服)) appeared far more frequently than terms of critique such as "plagiarism" (抄袭) or "appropriation" (挪用). Among the most frequently occurring words, "horse-face" (马面) appeared 127 times,

"culture" (文化) 89 times, "Dior" (迪奥/Dior) 94 times, and "tradition" (传统) 56 times, while "plagiarism" (抄袭) appeared only 48 times and "cultural appropriation" (文化挪用) just 16 times.



Data source: Manually collected from Xiaohongshu

Figure 4

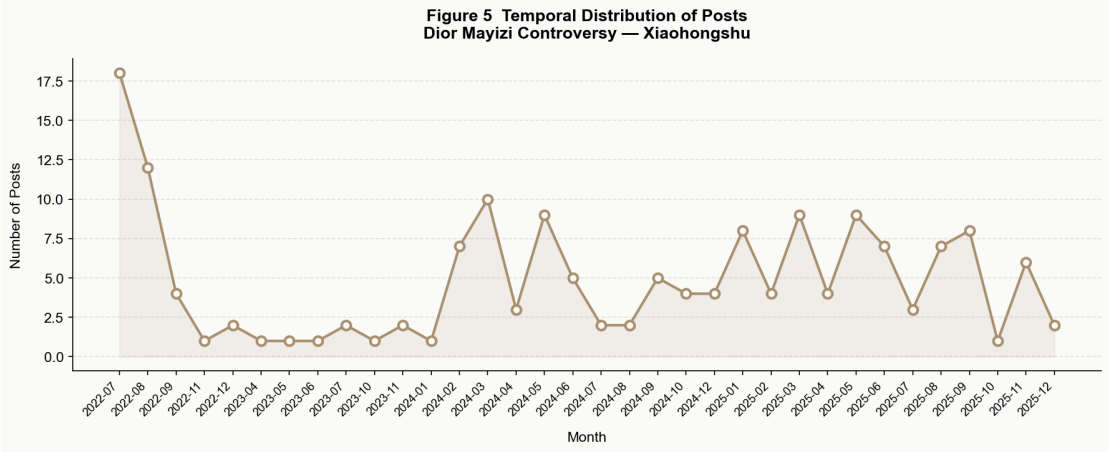
When aggregated, terms associated with cultural identity and affirmation appeared roughly 3.6 times more frequently than terms of critique, indicating that the core of collective imagination was oriented toward "what we have and how we preserve it" rather than "what they did wrong".

Notably, "confidence" (自信), though appearing only 22 times, was concentrated in high-engagement posts, indicating that this sentiment commanded disproportionately broad resonance among readers. Ethical vocabulary such as

"respect" (尊重, 14 occurrences) appeared more frequently than strictly legal terminology, reflecting a moral rather than juridical discursive foundation. The presence of design-related terms such as "aesthetics" (审美), "craft" (工艺), and "pattern" (纹样) further demonstrates that users were engaging substantively with the material and artistic dimensions of the mǎmiànqún, rather than remaining at the level of abstract nationalist sentiment.

6. Analysis

5.1 From Anger to Confidence



Data source: Manually collected from Xiaohongshu

Figure 5

Temporal data reveal three phases of evolution over the 3.5-year observation period.

In phase one (July 14 – 16, 2022), the data saw rapid mobilisation and collective outrage concentrated in the Plagiarism Accusation theme. Within just two days of the controversy's emergence, a surge of critical posts appeared, characterised by

clear moral directionality and group indignation. Phase 2 from late July to August marked a rational turn, with increasing neutral posts engaging legal analysis, design discussion, and historical investigation. Media participation and Dior's continued silence paradoxically drove discourse toward a more structured direction, as users filled the explanatory vacuum left by the brand. Phase 3 (2023 – 2025) saw a progressive shift toward a positive frame. National Pride posts rose, discussion moved from "what Dior did wrong" to "how beautiful Hanfu is", and the mǎmiànqún market experienced explosive growth alongside sustained design innovation. The proportion of Supportive sentiment stabilised at approximately 25%, reflecting a new, more confident mode of national imagination.

This trajectory from anger through reflection to confidence exemplifies Billig's dynamic process of banal nationalism. The initial outrage activated collective national consciousness, but what proved more significant was the long-term, rational cultural discussion and practice that followed. Ultimately, national imagination was sustained not through the maintenance of anger but through the active embrace and commercial dissemination of traditional culture. The notion that "the best protection is to wear it out into the world" became a recurring motif in later posts, signalling a transformation from defensive nationalism to assertive cultural confidence.

5.2 Alignment with Hypotheses

5.2.1 Hypothesis 1 Accepted: Decentralisation:

The 98.0% Decentralisation Index demonstrates that every user was an "imaginer", consistent with Anderson's theory that national identity is constructed by ordinary citizens rather than elites. Unlike Weibo, where a handful of verified accounts with millions of followers can single-handedly set the tone of a controversy, Xiaohongshu's discourse on the Dior affair was genuinely bottom-up.

This has important implications for understanding how digital platforms mediate national imagination. The platform's algorithmic structure, which promotes content discovery rather than follower-based amplification, appears to democratise participation in ways that align closely with Anderson's original emphasis on horizontal solidarity among strangers.

5.2.2 Hypothesis 2 Accpeted: Pluralism

The 57.7% "Other" category, the balance between Critical (25.5%) and Supportive (18.9%), and the 49.0% Neutral share show that discussion spanned a spectrum rather than clustering at opposing poles. Users simultaneously engaged legal, ethical, design, and commercial dimensions of the controversy, reflecting the complexity and openness of the imagined community. The coexistence of moral outrage, aesthetic appreciation, legal analysis, and historical curiosity

within a single discursive event suggests that national imagination is not a monolithic process but a multifaceted one, in which different individuals contribute different registers of engagement.

5.2.3 Hypothesis 3 Accepted: Cultural identification over confrontation

Cultural affirmation terms vastly outnumbered critique terms, at a ratio of approximately 3.6 to 1. The core of national imagination was self-affirmation rather than external confrontation. The celebration of Hanfu aesthetics and the encouragement of design innovation in the discourse reflect a positive, inward-looking logic of national imagination that draws its energy not from opposition to the West but from pride in one's own cultural heritage.

7. Conclusion and Discussion

6.1 Summary

This study reveals four principal findings through the analysis of 196 relevant Xiaohongshu posts.

i. Discourse was highly decentralised with ordinary users serving as the primary driving force and breaking the conventional "elite discourse" model that characterises Weibo.

ii. Discussion was multidimensional (57.7% falling outside any single thematic frame), exhibiting rationality and complexity rather than simple emotional outpouring.

iii. Sentiment was moderate (49.0% Neutral), with rational discussion predominating despite the presence of criticism, consistent with the

characteristics of banal nationalism.

iv. Discourse was positively oriented, with cultural affirmation vocabulary dominating word frequency and a clear temporal arc from initial anger toward sustained cultural confidence.

These findings suggest that in the social media age, national imagination has become more democratic, more rational, and more culturally grounded. Events trigger emotion, but what sustains the national community over time is the active embrace and everyday practice of one's own cultural heritage.

6.2 Theoretical Implications

Dior's silent response paradoxically intensified public discourse, with comment sections becoming battlefields of public opinion. This demonstrates that in the digital age, ordinary internet users, through aggregation, have acquired unprecedented discursive authority. The modern manifestation of Anderson's theory. National imagination no longer depends on print capitalism but is realised through the polyphonic clamour of social media. Hanfu and the mǎmiànqún serve as a material carrier that gives abstract national identity a concrete, wearable form. Anderson's framework requires revision to account for this shift from textual to embodied and digital modalities of national imagination: the body itself becomes the site through which the nation is collectively produced and affirmed.

From Alexander's (2003) performative perspective, Hanfu wearers and digital

protesters were not merely expressing pre-existing nationalist sentiment but actively staging national identity for a digital audience. The posting of Hanfu photographs, the sharing of historical knowledge, and the collective denunciation of Dior all functioned as social performances that produced, rather than merely reflected, communal solidarity. Meanwhile, Hebdige's (1979) concept of subcultural recuperation is complicated by this case, where the commercial success of the mǎmiànqún after the controversy did not neutralise the movement's resistant potential but rather amplified it, because the resistance was tied to national rather than class identity.

Our findings also extend Billig's framework. His research focused on Western symbolic systems such as flags and anthems; our study demonstrates that in non-Western social media environments, banal nationalism manifests as the rediscovery and active dissemination of traditional culture. The internet does not only reinforce existing national symbols but activates historical cultural resources, transforming them into everyday practices of national belonging.

6.3 Limitations

This study has several limitations. First, it analyses only Xiaohongshu, whose user base skews toward young women in first- and second-tier cities, limiting the sample's representativeness. Different platforms, for example Weibo's rapid-fire commentary, Douyin's short-video format, Bilibili's long-form video culture, all would likely yield different discursive patterns that cannot be captured here.

Second, the keyword-matching method for thematic and sentiment coding risks miscategorisation, particularly with rhetorical devices such as sarcasm, irony, and understatement; manual secondary verification of high-engagement posts would improve coding reliability. Third, the study analyses only post content (titles and body text) without incorporating comment-section discussions, which often represent the most intense and dialogical exchange of views. Fourth, the absence of user demographic data (including age, occupation, geographic location) precludes segmented analysis that might reveal differential roles of various social groups in the process of national imagination.

6.4 Future Directions

Future research could pursue several avenues. First, a cross-platform comparison examining whether Weibo skews critical, Douyin toward entertainment, and Xiaohongshu toward moderation would illuminate how platform algorithms and user demographics shape what might be called "platform nationalism".

Second, comment-text analysis using NLP for fine-grained sentiment detection, including sarcasm and irony recognition, would enhance classification precision and reveal the dialogical dynamics of collective imagination.

Third, longitudinal tracking linking post-event discourse to actual market data would clarify the conversion from discourse to action and from symbolic to

material nationalism.

Fourth, investigation of the mechanisms underlying nationalism's "moderation" could distinguish positive cultural identification from aggressive nationalism. Finally, an international dimension, analysing discourse on Twitter, YouTube, and other global platforms, would illuminate the collision and interaction between "Western" and "Chinese" perspectives in processes of national imagination.

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